Loved into Splendor

A Group Study on Ephesians 5:22-33

> Wives, submit to your own husbands, as to the Lord. For the husband is the head of the wife even as Christ is the head of the church, his body, and is himself its Savior. Now as the church submits to Christ, so also wives should submit in everything to their husbands.
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> Husbands, love your wives, as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her, that he might sanctify her, having cleansed her by the washing of water with the word, so that he might present the church to himself in splendor, without spot or wrinkle or any such thing, that she might be holy and without blemish. In the same way husbands should love their wives as their own bodies. He who loves his wife loves himself. For no one ever hated his own flesh, but nourishes and cherishes it, just as Christ does the church, because we are members of his body. "Therefore a man shall leave his father and mother and hold fast to his wife, and the two shall become one flesh." This mystery is profound, and I am saying that it refers to Christ and the church. However, let each one of you love his wife as himself, and let the wife see that she respects her husband.

Introduction

A note about Paul: when he wrote this letter, he was under house arrest in Rome — a shut-in, chained to a guard, unable to go where he wanted or see the people he loved. And Paul himself was single. He never married (1 Corinthians 7:7-8). Yet from that small room, this unmarried prisoner wrote the most profound vision of marriage in the entire Bible.

How? Because Paul understood that this passage is not ultimately about marriage advice. It is about something bigger. Every human marriage, Paul says, was designed from creation to be a portrait of Christ's love for His people. That is the love story this passage tells. Whether you are married, widowed, single, or separated — this love story includes you. You are part of the Bride.

Section 1: The Portrait

Focus: Ephesians 5:22-24 — *"Wives, submit to your own husbands, as to the Lord…"*

Ephesians 5:21 (for background)

> …submitting to one another out of reverence for Christ.

Notes

- The most important thing about v.22 is what is *not* there — and what *is*
  - In the oldest manuscripts, v.22 contains no independent verb
  - Paul's Greek flows straight from v.21: "submitting to one another out of reverence for Christ — wives, to your own husbands, as to the Lord"
  - The wife's submission is a specific instance of the mutual submission commanded of *every* believer
- English translations that supply "submit" in v.22 are not adding something foreign — they make explicit what the grammar already carries

    - But the structure matters: before Paul singles out wives, he has already placed their calling inside the wider call to mutual submission
- *hypotassō* — "submit"
    - Originally a military term: "to arrange under," like troops under a commander
    - Paul uses the middle voice → *voluntary self-ordering*
    - Not compliance forced from the outside, but trust offered from the inside
    - Compliance = doing what you're told
    - Submission = making someone else's will your own — choosing it freely because you trust the one who leads
- "As to the Lord" — four words that change everything
    - The wife's trust is ultimately directed toward Christ, not toward a fallible man
    - This dignifies submission and bounds it — no husband can demand what Christ would not
- Paul defines headship by *rescue*, not rule
    - He does not use the words for "ruler," "master," or "lord" — words available to him, words his audience would have expected
    - Instead: "he is himself its *Savior*" (v.23)
    - Whatever "head" means here, it is defined by rescue
- Paul devotes three verses to wives and nine to husbands
    - In a world where asking wives to defer was already the norm, Paul spends far more time telling husbands what *they* must do
    - The weight of obligation falls on the one with power — and that obligation is not to command but to sacrifice

Why this matters for us: This passage is about marriage, but the principle at its heart applies to every believer. Every one of us — married or not — is called to trust Christ with things we cannot control. Especially now. Especially here. When your body does not obey you the way it once did. When your schedule is set by someone else. When the future feels uncertain. Submission to Christ means saying, "I trust You with my life — even the parts I can't manage anymore. Even the parts that hurt." That is not weakness. It is the deepest kind of strength.

Reflection Questions

1. Paul calls Christ "the Savior of the body" (v.23). How has Christ been your Savior — not just at the cross, but in the daily realities of your life?

2. What is the difference between compliance (doing what you're told) and submission (making someone else's will your own)? Can you think of a time you experienced that difference?

Section 2: The Sacrifice

Focus: Ephesians 5:25-27 — *"Husbands, love your wives, as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her…"*

Ezekiel 16:8-10, 13-14 (for background)

> I bathed you with water and washed off your blood from you and anointed you with oil. I clothed you also with embroidered cloth and shod you with fine leather. I wrapped you in fine linen and covered you with silk… Your beauty was perfect through the splendor that I had bestowed on you, declares the Lord GOD.

Notes

- "Husbands, love your wives, as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her" — the command that shook the ancient world
    - No first-century philosopher, rabbi, or Roman lawmaker had ever told a husband to love his wife with self-sacrificial love
- *agapaō* — the Greek word Paul uses for "love"
    - Not feeling but decision, not emotion but action
    - Present tense command: *keep on loving* — not once, but as a way of life
- Paul raises the standard: not "love as a good man loves" but "love as *Christ* loved"
    - In the Greek, vv.25–27 are a single sentence compressing the entire arc of salvation:
    - **He gave himself up for her** (v.25) — the atonement
        - A completed, historical act of total self-expenditure
    - **That he might sanctify her, having cleansed her by the washing of water with the word** (v.26) — sanctification
        - *loutron* = "bath," not a quick rinse
        - Jewish brides immersed in a *mikveh* (ritual bath of flowing water) before their wedding
        - Greek brides bathed in water from a sacred spring
        - Paul echoes both: Christ bathes His Bride — He does not demand she clean herself up first
        - A thousand years earlier, God said through Ezekiel: "I bathed you with water and washed off your blood from you" (Ezekiel 16:9) — now Paul reveals who was doing the washing all along
    - **So that he might present the church to himself in splendor, without spot or wrinkle** (v.27) — glorification
        - The bride adorned in her wedding garments
        - *rhytida* ("wrinkle") — appears only here in the entire NT; the creases and lines that come with age and wear
        - Christ will present His Bride free from every mark of sin *and* every mark of decay
        - Not because they were hidden, but because they were healed

Why this matters for us: This is the heart of the passage — and the heart of the gospel. * Christ did not wait for us to become beautiful before He loved us. * He loved us *into* beauty. * He loved us *into* splendor. * The One who loves you is not finished with you. * still washing * still sanctifying * still preparing you for a day when you will be presented "in splendor, without spot or wrinkle." * That day is coming. Every ache, every limitation, every scar — He is working all of it toward glory. * Christ does not love us because we are lovely. He loves us until we are.

Reflection Questions

1. Christ promises to present His church "without spot or wrinkle." What does that promise mean to you at this stage of life?

2. The word for "washing" means a full bath — not a quick rinse. What areas of your heart do you wish Christ would wash clean?

Section 3: The Mystery

Focus: Ephesians 5:28-32 — *"This mystery is profound, and I am saying that it refers to Christ and the church."*

Genesis 2:23-24 (for background)

> Then the man said, "This at last is bone of my bones and flesh of my flesh; she shall be called Woman, because she was taken out of Man." Therefore a man shall leave his father and mother and hold fast to his wife, and they shall become one flesh.

Notes

- Two remarkably tender words for how Christ treats His church (v.29)
  - *ektrephō* — "to nourish, to feed to maturity"
    - Same word Paul uses in Ephesians 6:4 for fathers raising their children
  - *thalpō* — "to warm, to brood over"
    - Used elsewhere of a nursing mother warming a child against her body (1 Thessalonians 2:7)
  - These are not words of authority — they are words of tenderness
  - Christ feeds His people to fullness and holds them close
- Paul quotes Genesis 2:24 — the oldest verse about marriage in the Bible
  - "Hold fast" = *proskollaō* — literally "to be glued to"
  - Same word used of Ruth clinging to Naomi and refusing to let go (Ruth 1:14)
  - Same word used of Israel being told to cling to God (Deuteronomy 10:20)
  - A bond so strong it cannot be dissolved without destroying what has been joined
- "This mystery is profound… it refers to Christ and the church" (v.32)
  - *mystērion* — not something puzzling, but a secret hidden in God's plan and now revealed
  - Marriage was never just about two people
  - From the Garden of Eden, marriage was a living portrait of Christ's love for His people
  - The "one flesh" of husband and wife was always an icon of the union between Christ and His church
  - We can finally see what was always there
- Paul himself never married, yet wrote the most profound theology of marriage in the Bible
  - He understood that every earthly marriage points beyond itself to a greater reality
  - You do not need to be currently married to stand in awe of this mystery — you need only to be part of the Bride

Why this matters for us: Some of you have had beautiful marriages. Some have had difficult ones. Some never married. Some have lost the one you loved most. But Paul's point is this: the earthly marriage was always a shadow of something greater.
Christ left His Father's house — that is what the incarnation was. He "held fast" to His Bride — that is what the cross was. And He will never let go — that is what eternity is. You are nourished. You are cherished. You are held fast. Not by a human spouse who may be gone now, but by Christ, who said, "I will never leave you nor forsake you" (Hebrews 13:5).

Reflection Questions

1. Paul says Christ "nourishes and cherishes" the church — using words for feeding and warming. In what ways has Christ nourished or warmed you recently?

2. "This mystery is profound." What is one thing about God's love that still amazes you, even after all these years of knowing Him?

Section 4: The Ending That Is a Beginning

Focus: Ephesians 5:33 — *"However, let each one of you love his wife as himself, and let the wife see that she respects her husband."*

Revelation 19:7, 9

> Let us rejoice and exult and give him the glory, for the marriage of the Lamb has come, and his Bride has made herself ready… Blessed are those who are invited to the marriage supper of the Lamb.

Notes

- V.33 opens with *plēn* ("however" / "nevertheless") — descending from christological heights to the runway
  - After all that theology, Paul lands with a very practical sentence: husband, love your wife as yourself; wife, respect your husband
- "Respect" = *phobeō*
  - Sometimes translated "fear," but here it means deep reverence — recognizing the weight and worth of another person
  - Same word family Paul used to open this section: "submitting to one another out of reverence (*phobos*) for Christ" (v.21)
  - The passage begins and ends with reverence — reverence for Christ flows into every relationship
- Paul's marriage instruction is not the end of the story — it is a chapter inside the Bible's biggest love story, running from Genesis to Revelation:
  - **Genesis 2** — God creates the first marriage
  - **Hosea** — God calls Himself a faithful husband to an unfaithful people
  - **Isaiah 54** — "Your Maker is your husband, the LORD of hosts is his name"
  - **Ezekiel 16** — God washes, clothes, adorns, and marries His people
  - **Song of Solomon** — the Lover and the Beloved
  - **Ephesians 5** — the great reveal: marriage was always about Christ and the church
  - **Revelation 19** — "The marriage of the Lamb has come, and his Bride has made herself ready"
  - **Revelation 21** — the Bible ends where it began: with a marriage
- "Blessed are those who are *invited*" (Revelation 19:9)
  - The angel does not say "blessed are the bride and groom" — he says "blessed are those who are *invited*"
  - The invitation does not expire with age, does not depend on your health, does not require walking down an aisle
  - It requires only that you say yes to the Bridegroom

Why this matters for us: For many of us, the earthly chapter of marriage is closed. A spouse has passed. A ring sits in a drawer. The house you shared belongs to someone else now. But hear this: the great chapter is still ahead. The Bible does not end with a funeral. It ends with a wedding feast. Whatever you have lost — a spouse, your health, your independence, your home — the best is not behind you. The best is ahead. The Lamb's supper is prepared. The Bride is being made ready. And you — sitting in this room, in this chair, in this body — you are part of that Bride. One day, every "spot" of sin and every "wrinkle" of age will be gone. Not because you earned it, but because He loved you into splendor.

Reflection Questions

1. The Bible begins with a marriage (Genesis 2) and ends with a marriage (Revelation 19). What does it mean to you that God chose a wedding as the final image of eternity?

2. Paul lands from the heights of theology with a very practical verse: love, respect. What is one practical way you can show love or respect to someone this week — a roommate, a caretaker, a family member?

For Reflection

This week, each morning when you wake up, before your feet touch the floor (or before you reach for the call button), say these words quietly: *"I am loved. I am being made ready. The best is still ahead."* That is what Ephesians 5 says about you.

If you are a widow or widower: thank God for the marriage you had, even with its imperfections. It was a shadow of something greater. And that greater love has not ended — it has only begun.

If you never married: you have never been without a Bridegroom. Christ has held fast to you your whole life.

If your marriage was painful: Christ knows. He married a bride who was unfaithful too (Hosea 1-3). And He never stopped loving her. He never stopped washing. He never stopped preparing her for splendor.

This week, ask one person — a roommate, an aide, a visitor — "How can I pray for you?" You may be the only person who asks them that today. A member of the Bride who intercedes for others is doing the most important work in the building.

The passage began with a portrait of trust (v.22) and ended with a wedding feast (Revelation 19:7). Between those bookends is the whole gospel: Christ loved, Christ sacrificed, Christ washes, Christ presents in splendor. And you — right where you are — are part of that story. None of it is wasted. All of it matters. The Bridegroom is coming. And He is not ashamed of His Bride.

Key Terms at a Glance

English (ESV)	Greek	Meaning
"Submit"	*hypotassō*	Voluntarily arrange under — a military term turned relational; self-chosen, not forced
"Head"	*kephalē*	Head — in context, qualified by "he is himself its Savior"; headship defined by rescue
"Love"	*agapaō*	Self-giving, volitional love — not feeling but action; Christ's love as the standard
"Gave himself up"	*paredōken*	Handed over — the same word used for the crucifixion; total self-expenditure
"Washing"	*loutron*	Bath — full immersion, echoing the bridal *mikveh* and baptism
"In splendor"	*endoxon*	Glorious, radiant — the bride adorned for presentation
"Without spot or wrinkle"	*spilon … rhytida*	Spot (moral stain) and wrinkle (mark of decay) — both removed by Christ
"Nourishes"	*ektrephei*	Feeds to maturity — the same word used for raising children
"Cherishes"	*thalpei*	Warms, broods over — used of a mother warming a child against her body
"Hold fast"	*proskollaō*	To be glued to — an unbreakable bond; same word as Ruth clinging to Naomi
"Mystery"	*mystērion*	A hidden truth now revealed — marriage was always a portrait of Christ and the church

English (ESV)	Greek	Meaning
“Respects”	*phobētai*	Deep reverence — the same word family as “reverence for Christ” in v.21

Passage Structure at a Glance

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THE PORTRAIT (vv.22-24)
  → Wives: voluntary trust, "as to the Lord"
  → The husband as head — defined by: "he is the Savior"

THE SACRIFICE (vv.25-27)
  → Husbands: love as Christ loved — gave himself up
  → Christ's threefold work:
       gave himself    (ATONEMENT)
       sanctifies      (SANCTIFICATION)
       presents in splendor  (GLORIFICATION)

THE MYSTERY (vv.28-32)
  → "No one ever hated his own flesh"
  → Nourishes and cherishes — as Christ does the church
  → Genesis 2:24: "the two shall become one flesh"
  → THE GREAT REVEAL: "This mystery is profound —
       it refers to Christ and the church"

THE LANDING (v.33)
  → Husband: love your wife as yourself
  → Wife: respect your husband
  → From cosmic mystery back to daily practice
  → But the story does not end here — Revelation 19:7
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